But it did nothing for John of Gaunt. Castile remained in the hands of Enrique Trastámara's son, and John of Gaunt was still without a crown. The king of Portugal offered to keep on fighting against Castile, and Parliament reluctantly agreed to fund another invasion force for John of Gaunt: twelve hundred knights, two thousand archers, a thousand foot soldiers, and enough money to pay them all for at least six months.

In answer, the king of Castile appealed once again to the court of France for help. Eighteen-year-old Charles VI decided that an invasion of England would serve to draw the English away from Castile. "Do not be uneasy," he wrote back to the king of Castile, "for we will occupy the English at home, until they do not know which way to turn; and when England is completely destroyed, we will come to your aid."

"With this answer the King of Castile contented himself as well as he could," Froissart tells us. "Indeed, he could not help himself, for no knights and squires came to him from France, all were so anxious to invade England." The invasion was planned for the August of 1386. A new tax was declared in France, to fund the building of more warships; Charles VI ordered vessels commandeered from every port in France. ("Never since God created the world were there seen such number of large ships together," Froissart adds.) Months were spent baking ship's biscuit, salting meat, and drying egg yolks so that they could be powdered and stored on board. In England a new rumor arose every day: the French were just about to land in Dover or at Sandwich; the fleet would depart any day now; the fleet would first surround and besiege Calais; Charles himself would lead the attack.[3]

The whole glorious enterprise fizzled out abruptly. The French fleet did not catch a fair wind until the end of October. On All Saints' Eve, the entire fleet sailed out of the harbor of Sluys, where it had been assembled for an entire year. Twenty miles out of port, says Walsingham, "a contrary wind began blowing in their faces, and drove them all back home . . . and also drove them into collisions with each other so that some of them were wrecked in the very entrance to the port of Sluys."[4]

No second attempt followed. No French force ever arrived at Castile either, although by 1387 John of Gaunt had realized the fruitlessness of his attempts to get Castile's throne, and instead had arranged for the marriage of one of his daughters to the king of Portugal's son. He would not gain a throne, but perhaps one day he would be the grandfather of a king.

The invasion-that-wasn't was symptomatic of the complete lack of leadership in Paris. Charles VI was a flighty and uninterested ruler, his uncles constantly jostled each other for more power at court, and intrigues, private agreements, and feuds prevented any unified war strategy from taking place.